

Large Chilean Frog at Risk from Climate Change

A large frog species that lived alongside dinosaurs and is considered a "living fossil" is now losing ground in its native Chile.

Climate change and human actions are damaging the creature's living environment, or habitat.

The Helmeted Water Toad is one of the largest frogs in the world, growing up to over 30 centimeters in length and weighing up to one kilogram.

The amphibian has experienced little genetic change for millions of years. But now its future is at risk, scientists say.

"It's sad that a species that managed to coexist with dinosaurs, that managed to resist a mass extinction, is now threatened by human beings," said Melissa Cancino. Cancino is an animal doctor and founder of Proyecto Anfibia, a group that works on amphibian research and education in Chile.

The Helmeted Water Toad's environment covers a large part of the country, but its population is suspected to have decreased by at least 30 percent since 1990. The creature is identified as "vulnerable" on the International Union for Conservation of Nature's (IUCN) Red List.

Climate change, habitat changes, environmental decline and pollution have all caused the Helmeted Water Toad's numbers to decline, Cancino said. Poor water and waste management have also threatened the frog's living environment.

Matias Faundez, another member of Proyecto Anfibia, has seen the damage first hand.

"This estuary runs through the whole city, and has plenty of illegal run-offs," he said as he walked through a stream outside of Valparaiso. "Even so," he added, "the frog manages to survive."

I'm John Russell.

Rodrigo Gutierrez reported on this story for Reuters. John Russell adapted it for VOA Learning English.

Vocabulary

species - น. ชนิดของสิ่งมีชีวิต, สายพันธุ์

amphibian - น. สัตว์ครึ่งบกครึ่งน้ำ (เช่น กบ)

vulnerable - adj. เปราะบาง, อ่อนแอ, ซึ่งถูกโจมตีหรือทำลายได้ง่าย

extinction - n. การสูญพันธุ์

estuary - n. ปากแม่น้ำ, บริเวณที่แม่น้ำไหลลงสู่ทะเล

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What is the main subject of the article and its current state in Chile?

- A) A dinosaur species that is thriving.
- B) A "living fossil" frog species that is losing ground.
- C) A new amphibian species discovered in Chile.
- D) A type of fish that coexisted with dinosaurs.

2. According to the article, what are the two main factors damaging the frog's habitat?

- A) Natural predators and disease.
- B) Climate change and human actions.
- C) Volcanic activity and earthquakes.
- D) Deforestation and wildfires.

3. What are the approximate maximum size and weight of the Helmeted Water Toad mentioned in the article?

- A) 20 centimeters in length and 500 grams in weight.
- B) Over 30 centimeters in length and up to one kilogram in weight.
- C) 15 centimeters in length and 200 grams in weight.
- D) 40 centimeters in length and over two kilograms in weight.

4. What historical characteristic of the Helmeted Water Toad is now being challenged by its current risk?

- A) Its ability to adapt quickly to new environments.
- B) Its preference for living in cold water.
- C) Its long period of little genetic change.
- D) Its history of rapid population growth.

5. Who is Melissa Cancino and what is her primary concern regarding the Helmeted Water Toad?

- A) A scientist who discovered the toad, concerned about its size.
- B) An animal doctor and founder of Proyecto Anfibia, concerned about human threats.
- C) A government official focused on climate change policy.

D) A historian studying the coexistence of species with dinosaurs.

6. What is the main focus of Proyecto Anfibia, the group founded by Melissa Cancino?

- A) Preserving dinosaur fossils in Chile.
- B) Promoting human development in amphibian habitats.
- C) Amphibian research and education in Chile.
- D) Developing new medicines from amphibian species.

7. What is the estimated percentage decrease in the Helmeted Water Toad's population since 1990?

- A) At least 10 percent.
- B) Exactly 20 percent.
- C) At least 30 percent.
- D) Over 50 percent.

8. How is the Helmeted Water Toad classified on the International Union for Conservation of Nature's (IUCN) Red List?

- A) Endangered
- B) Critically Endangered
- C) Vulnerable
- D) Least Concern

9. According to Melissa Cancino in Paragraph 8, which of the following is NOT listed as a cause for the Helmeted Water Toad's decline?

- A) Climate change
- B) Habitat changes
- C) Natural predation
- D) Pollution

10. Besides broader environmental issues, what two specific management problems are highlighted as threats to the frog's living environment?

- A) Poor forest management and excessive fishing.
- B) Inefficient irrigation and agricultural runoff.
- C) Poor water and waste management.
- D) Lack of protected areas and tourism.

11. What is Matias Faundez's connection to the environmental damage affecting the Helmeted Water Toad?

- A) He is a government researcher who conducted a study.
- B) He is a journalist who reported on the issue from afar.
- C) He is a member of Proyecto Anfibia who observed the damage directly.
- D) He is a local resident who only heard about the problems.

12. Where did Matias Faundez make his observations about the polluted estuary?

- A) Inside the city of Valparaiso.
- B) In a remote mountain region.
- C) A stream outside of Valparaiso.
- D) Along the coastline near the ocean.

13. What specific issue did Matias Faundez highlight regarding the estuary he observed?

- A) It was completely dry due to drought.
- B) It had an abundance of unique aquatic plants.
- C) It suffered from numerous illegal run-offs.
- D) It was heavily used for recreational boating.

14. Despite the significant environmental challenges mentioned, what surprising fact did Matias Faundez note about the frog in the estuary?

- A) It has developed new genetic mutations.
- B) It has migrated to a different habitat.
- C) It manages to survive in the polluted conditions.
- D) Its population is actually increasing.

15. What was John Russell's role in the creation of this VOA Learning English story?

- A) He was the original reporter for Reuters.
- B) He conducted the field research in Chile.
- C) He adapted the story for VOA Learning English.
- D) He is the founder of Proyecto Anfibia.